BOOTH SHEET · EP. 1 HOT COFFEE

VOICE-OVER · 20 LINES · 547 WORDS · ABOUT 4 MINUTES READ · PLAN 30–45 MINUTES

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1. **Mic:** the same one as the ep. 2 voice-over. In QuickTime: File → New Audio Recording, click the arrow next to the record button, pick that mic and set Quality to Maximum.
2. **Room tone:** before the first line, record 5 seconds of silence.
3. **Slate:** one long recording is fine. Before each line, say its number as printed (“four,” “twenty-one”), wait a beat, then read.
4. **Flubs:** stop, pause, and start that *sentence* again. Don’t restart the whole line; the mistakes get cut.
5. **Another try:** say the ID again plus “take two.” The last take is used unless you say otherwise.
6. **Pace:** your own, a little slower than talking. Breathe at the end of each line on this sheet; on long ones, at any comma.
7. **Breaks:** stop whenever you like. Several files across several sessions are fine; tick the boxes as you go.

S01

COLD OPEN · ~11 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “one”

A woman spills McDonald’s coffee on herself and sues.

A jury gives her nearly three million dollars.

You’ve heard this one.

It’s been a punchline for thirty years.

Cold open. Tell it the way everyone tells it, a little amused. The turn comes in your on-camera line.

S04

ACT 1: THE JOKE · ~10 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “four”

Here’s the version most of us got.

Careless customer.

Of course coffee is hot, it’s coffee.

Greedy lawsuit, runaway jury, lottery ticket.

The joke version. Light, almost a shrug. Let the clichés sound like clichés.

S06

ACT 2: THE SPILL · ~15 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “six”

February 27, 1992.

Albuquerque, New Mexico.

Stella Liebeck is 79.

She’s in the passenger seat of her grandson’s car, a 1989 Ford Probe.

No cup holders.

Plain and exact. Dates and the car are facts, not drama.

Say it: Liebeck: LEE-beck · Albuquerque: AL-buh-kur-kee

S07

ACT 2: THE SPILL · ~11 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “seven”

They’ve just bought breakfast at a drive-through, and he’s parked so she can add cream and sugar.

She puts the cup between her knees and pulls the lid toward her.

The whole cup goes into her lap.

Slow down on the last three sentences; the picture follows each action as you say it.

S08

ACT 2: THE SPILL · ~5 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “eight”

She was wearing cotton sweatpants.

They soaked up the coffee and held it against her skin.

S09

ACT 3: THE INJURIES · ~12 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “nine”

This is where the joke falls apart.

Third-degree burns on six percent of her skin, and lesser burns over sixteen percent.

Third degree means full thickness: the burn goes through every layer.

Even. The numbers do the work. A beat before “Third degree means.”

S10

ACT 3: THE INJURIES · ~8 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “ten”

Eight days in the hospital.

Skin grafts.

She lost about twenty pounds, down to eighty-three.

Two years of treatment.

Four short items. A beat between each.

S11

ACT 3: THE INJURIES · ~18 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “eleven”

Why so bad?

Temperature.

McDonald’s own standard was to hold its coffee at 180 to 190 degrees.

An expert testified that at 190, liquid can cause a third-degree burn in about three seconds.

At 180, about twelve to fifteen.

The temperatures and seconds are the heart of the case. Clear, unhurried.

S13

ACT 4: THE $800 · ~14 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “thirteen”

Here’s the part nobody tells you.

She didn’t start by suing.

She asked McDonald’s to cover her costs: her medical bills, some future care, and the income her daughter lost caring for her.

About twenty thousand dollars.

“Here’s the part nobody tells you” is the pivot of the episode. Give it a breath.

S14

ACT 4: THE $800 · ~2 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “fourteen”

McDonald’s offered eight hundred.

Four words. Flat. Let it sit.

S17

ACT 5: THE TRIAL · ~16 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “seventeen”

August 1994.

The trial runs about a week and a half, and the jury learns something that changes the case.

Between 1982 and 1992, McDonald’s received more than seven hundred reports of people burned by its coffee.

Long one. Start a fresh take at any sentence if you need to.

S18

ACT 5: THE TRIAL · ~5 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “eighteen”

The company had already paid more than half a million dollars settling burn claims.

S19

ACT 5: THE TRIAL · ~10 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “nineteen”

Its quality-assurance manager testified.

In substance, his position was that seven hundred reports weren’t enough to make the company change how it served coffee.

“In substance” is doing legal work: this is a paraphrase, not a quote. Keep it level.

S21

ACT 5: THE TRIAL · ~13 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “twenty-one”

The jury said yes.

But they didn’t find her blameless.

They put twenty percent of the fault on her.

So her compensatory damages, two hundred thousand, were cut by twenty percent, to one hundred sixty thousand.

Three numbers in a row. Steady pace so each lands.

S23

ACT 5: THE TRIAL · ~14 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “twenty-three”

Then punitive damages.

Her lawyer suggested a number tied to the company’s own sales: two days of McDonald’s coffee revenue, about 1.35 million dollars a day.

The jury awarded 2.7 million.

The money line. Don’t sell it; the jury did.

S25

ACT 6: AFTER THE VERDICT · ~10 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “twenty-five”

The judge cut the punitive damages to four hundred eighty thousand, three times the compensatory award.

Total: six hundred forty thousand dollars.

S26

ACT 6: AFTER THE VERDICT · ~10 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “twenty-six”

Both sides were headed for appeal.

Instead they settled, confidentially.

Nobody outside knows the final number, and anyone who tells you they do is guessing.

Dry. The last sentence is a warning to the audience, not a joke.

S27

ACT 6: AFTER THE VERDICT · ~10 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “twenty-seven”

Stella Liebeck died in 2004.

She was ninety-one.

Her daughter said the settlement paid for a live-in nurse.

By then, the story had a life of its own.

Gentle. This is the only line about her as a person.

Say it: Liebeck: LEE-beck

S29

THE HOLDING · ~6 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “twenty-nine”

So what does this case actually stand for?

Not ‘you can get rich spilling coffee.’

Three things.

Turn the page. “Three things,” then stop.

S30

THE HOLDING · ~19 S AT TEMP PACE

SAY: “thirty”

One: comparative fault.

The jury put twenty percent of the blame on her, and her award shrank to match.

Two: punitive damages are about what a company knew and did.

Seven hundred prior reports were the case.

Three: the system has brakes.

A judge cut the punitive award by more than eighty percent.

Long one. Start a fresh take at “One:”, “Two:” or “Three:” if you need to.

END OF VOICE-OVER · THE ON-CAMERA PIECES ARE ON THE RECORDING SCRIPT